al or Viable. Completing the competitor comparison early on helps you to:

- Identify industry trends related to your JTBDs/workflows
- Identify gaps in our own feature offerings
- Use the comparison findings for planning purposes
- Address the identified gaps before evaluating for Competitive and Complete maturity

If you're not able to conduct a competitor comparison early on, that's ok; there's still tremendous value in conducting it during the later stages of Category Maturity Scoring.

Conducting a competitor comparison should be done at least annually if you're at Complete Otherwise, when you intend to make a category shift.

Steps to follow

A Product Manager will lead their quad team, in collaboration with a Product Marketing Manager or Developer Advocate, in conducting the competitor comparison. Reason: A Product Manager is best suited for leading the comparison effort, because they have a detailed view into the JTBDs, competitors, and features. The following steps walkthrough the process for a competitor comparison:

- Step 1 - Choose the competitor(s)
  - If there are many competitors in the space, it's advised to focus on the top competitor(s).
  - The competitor(s) being evaluated should be justifiable as a direct competitor with the JTBDs in mind. Components such as market share, feature overlap, etc. should be considered when determining which competitors to compare against.
  - If the competitor requires a paid subscription, you will need to conduct the comparison to the best of your ability using publicly available sources. Also, reach out to the competition Slack channel to see if we can leverage any third-party vendors to help expand our understanding of the competitor.
  - Depending on the competitor, you may need to gain approval through the Individual Use Software process.

- Step 2 - Follow Legal guidelines
  - Since we're reviewing competitors, it's important that you review and follow the Guidelines for leveraging third-party SaaS free trials to gain competitive intelligence (only available to team members) and the Guidelines on public discussion of competitor product features.
  - We also need to be mindful of the acceptable use policies of the competitors we're evaluating. It's often difficult to understand the acceptable use policies of the competitors you're about to evaluate. Rather than try to interpret it yourself, ask your question on the legal Slack channel before proceeding with the competitor comparison.

- Step 3 - Decide on the JTBDs to focus on
  - The JTBDs should align directly with the Category Maturity Scorecard testing you're also evaluating (or already have evaluated). The process on how to identify JTBDs is outlined here.
  - Sometimes, the scope of a JTBD can span across multiple stage groups, resulting in tighter collaboration across different teams. One suggestion on how to best approach that scenario is to hold an async workshop to land on a set of agreed-upon JTBDs while also discussing the division of labor and timing considerations for the competitor comparison.

- Step 4 - Identify the top competitor(s)
  - Keep this in the context of the JTBDs that you're evaluating.

- Step 5 - Copy the template & populate the JTBDs you're evaluating
  - Review the example within the template for guidance.
  - Link the deck from the issue and make sure "View" settings of your completed deck are for GitLab internal only, as these decks should not be viewed external to GitLab. As a reminder, it's important not to share your screen if you're presenting the deck on a public stream or a recorded meeting that will appear on YouTube.

- Step 6 - Compare the functionality/features that solve for the JTBDs
  - Be sure to include screenshots of both GitLab and the competitor to illustrate differences in the experiences/features related to the JTBDs.
  - If you discover either GitLab or the competitor(s) don't offer a solution (feature) to solve for the JTBD being compared, that's probably an indicator that there's a gap.

- Step 7 - Rate each JTBD
  - Each slide should be an opportunity to show your work and justification behind your rating.
  - Remember: the competitor comparison should be completely data/evidence driven.

- Step 8 - Document/update the scoring
  - Either add or amend the existing category score on this handbook page with the appropriate signal

- Step 9 - Identifying actionable steps to take
  - Now that the gaps are identified and ratings are complete, it's time to develop an action plan to move maturity up and/or achieve best in class
  - (WIP to a handbook page on suggestions on how to do this - coming soon)

Scoring best in class

For this process to be sustainable, we need to provide an adaptable and simple methodology to add to the Category Maturity Scorecard framework that answers the question, "Is GitLab the best-in-class for this category?"

The approach to rating

As a Category Maturity Scorecard is based on Jobs to be Done (JTBD), it makes sense to use the same target jobs in the competitor comparison. So, we use our own judgment and market knowledge to evaluate each JTBD separately and inform the overall best in class rating.

Throughout the Category Maturity Scorecard process, we assess one or more JTBDs to understand the representative tasks that users will perform within GitLab (a JTBD comprises multiple tasks). For the competitor comparison, we heuristically evaluate those same tasks within the competitor product. For each task, we objectively assess whether GitLab or the competitor has the superior experience and/or feature offering.

Indicating best in class

To indicate if a JTBD is best in class, we use a simple rating in the form of an amendment to the existing Category Maturity Score:

- (+) Indicates best in class
- Bold (+) indicates a GitLab sweep, where GitLab scored better than the competitor on every JTBD
- (-) Indicates not best in class
- No marking means competitor analysis was not performed.

Example:

- 'Viable' - The absence of any marking indicates that a competitor analysis was not performed
- 'Viable (+)' - (+) indicates best in class
- 'Viable (+)' - (+) indicates best in class and a GitLab sweep, where GitLab scored better than the competitor on every JTBD
- 'Viable (-)' - (-) indicates not best in class

Identifying heuristics

Another way of asking this is: "what are we looking at with competitors in these comparisons?" The short answer is: focus on what's important for the user while considering the JTBD. Heuristics must apply to both GitLab and the other competitor(s), thereby being able to compare across both applications.

It's also critical to keep the heuristics objective and factual. That means doing your best to exclude your own personal opinions from the heuristics being used. Here are some examples of objective vs. subjective heuristics:

Objective heuristics ·	Subjective heuristics ·
Number of steps to complete the JTBD	Quicker
Time it takes to complete the JTBD	Faster
Ability to complete the JTBD within a single page	More convenient
Can complete the JTBD	Better
How the JTBD can be completed	More/less features

Sometimes, a heuristic can simply be how something is being done, for comparison's sake. Meaning, it may not be rateable. For example, it could define how a call is being made to a database. If it's a differentiator and important for the user trying to complete a JTBD, it can surface up as a heuristic. If you have any questions on this topic, or would like a review, please consult your UX Researcher.

If you're having trouble determining if your heuristics are objective vs. subjective, consider the below:

- If you're using words like 'better', 'faster', 'more', etc in defining your heuristics, they're probably subjective heuristics and need to be adjusted to be more objective.
- If your heuristics can be compared using numbers, yes/no, or descriptions, then they're probably objective heuristics.

Tip: it's sometimes best to go into a comparison without heuristics identified ahead of time.

Heuristics can often reveal themselves to you once the comparison is underway. A real example:

- In comparing features, it became clearly apparent that one application contained far more steps than the other application to complete the same task. In this example, a comparable heuristic became 'number of steps'.

A good number of heuristics to aim for per JTBD is 3 or 4. Focus on what you think are the important differentiators that can help tell the story of 'best in class'.

Example case study

JTBD: When signing up for a service, I want to move through the process as quickly as possible, so I can start using the product effectively.

Potential heuristics:

- Time
- Number of steps

To perform the competitor analysis for this, you would need to perform the sign-up process for both GitLab and the competitor, while keeping track of the heuristics you identified.

After going through and documenting each heuristic across both applications, there are 3 possible outcomes:

1. GitLab is better in more heuristics. (GitLab is best in class for this JTBD.)
1. Competitor is better in more heuristics. (GitLab is not best in class for this JTBD.)
1. It is an even split. (GitLab is not best in class for this JTBD, because "best" does not imply a tie. You are not the best if someone is as good as you are.)

This gives us a rating for each JTBD, as to which application is better. For the category rating, the same tie breaking applies

Thus you arrive at your overall score for the competitor analysis.

SECTION: product/ux/category-maturity/category-maturity-scorecards/index.md

Intro and Goal

The Category Maturity (CM) Scorecard is a Summative Evaluation that takes into account the entire experience as defined by a Job to be Done (JTBD), instead of individual improvement(s), which are often measured through Usability Testing (i.e. Solution Validation). This specialized process provides data to help us grade the maturity of our product.

The goal of this process is to produce data as objectively as possible given time and resource constraints. For this reason, the process is more rigorous than other UX research methods, and it focuses more on measures and less on thoughts and verbal feedback.

To produce data in which we have confidence, the data should be as free of subjective judgement as possible, relying on observed metrics and self-reported user sentiment. Our goal is to compare data over time to see how additions and improvements have impacted product maturity in a quantifiable way. To facilitate this, we've made this process prescriptive, so that it can be consistently applied by all Product Designers in all categories of our product.

Some things to keep in mind

Sometimes the JTBD you need to evaluate occurs over a period of time, such as a multi-step process when responding to an alert. For these cases, it's appropriate to include the phrase '(a period of time) has passed' when moving to the next phase of the JTBD in the CM Scorecard scenario.

Occasionally, teams run into situations where they learn something surprising from a CM Scorecard -- for example, even though the score for this single research initiative is high enough to move maturity up, they believe based on the findings that it's not ready, yet. In this case, the Product Manager and Product Designer should use their good judgement about addressing fundamental problems before changing maturity and communicate that decision to stakeholders.

If you have questions, suggestions for improvement, or find this process doesn't meet the needs of your users or product category, reach out to the UX Researcher for your group.

Any Category Maturity Scorecard effort should have a corresponding issue created in the GitLab UX Research project. Ensure the label CM Scorecard is applied to the issue to aid in tracking UX research efforts.

It is important to note that there are specifc requirements that should be met before considering a Category Maturity Scorecard study. These requirements are designed to capture:

- Usability progression
- Adherance to the GitLab Design Standards
- How we stack up against at least one competitor

The below table outlines the requirements for each maturity level:

Category level	Conducted with?	Usability status	GitLab Design Standards criteria	Competitive add-on
Complete	External users on the JTBDs	A (High quality/Exceeds expectations). This is the same grading system as the UX Scorecard grading rubric. / The path for all JTBDs are well established, intentional in design, and clear in the outcomes they enable users to reach.	Meets 100% of GitLab design standards	GitLab scores: Best in class
Competitive	External users on the JTBDs	B (Meets expectations). This is the same grading system as the UX Scorecard grading rubric. / The path for the primary and related JTBDs are well established, intentional in design, and clear in the outcomes they enable users to reach.	Meets 100% of GitLab design standards	GitLab scores: Equal or

Best in class |
| Viable | Internal users who are dogfooding | C (Average). This is the same grading system from the UX Scorecard grading rubric. / The path for the primary JTBD is well established, intentional in design, and clear in the outcome it enables users to reach.
| Meets 100% of GitLab design standards | (not required) |
| Minimal | (not required) | D (Poor). This is the same grading system from the UX Scorecard grading rubric. / The path for the primary JTBD is established, intentional in design, and nearing a clear outcome for users to reach.
| Meets at least 80% of GitLab design standards | (not required) |

Refer to the Category Maturity page to understand scoring of a Category Maturity Scorecard study.

Previously completed Category Maturity Scorecards can be found in this epic.

How UX Scorecards relate to Category Maturity Scorecards

See how Scorecards relate to Category Maturity Scorecards in the UX Scorecards handbook page.

All of the UX Scorecards can be found in this epic.

Steps for running a Category Maturity Scorecard study

Step 0: Jobs to be Done (JTBD)

Category Maturity Scorecards are about judging the quality of experiences against a defined and confident JTBD. JTBD are the umbrella component of our product design process, and we use them to guide our product strategy and features. For that reason, before you begin the CM Scorecard process, you should have one or more JTBD that you feel confident about.

Refer to the JTBD page to learn how to write JTBD.

Before moving to Step 1, you first need to select the high-priority JTBD statements that you want to assess and translate them into script scenarios. The number of scenarios you will create per job statement often depends on the complexity of the features you're testing. Due to time limitations in a user research study (generally 30 to 60 minutes per participant), we recommend assessing no more than 2 job statements per study to help avoid participant fatigue. However, if you want to test more than 2 job statements, you can. Just be mindful of the total time it will take to run the study.

Tip: Since job statements are persona and solution agnostic, you might find them to be too broad to serve as guidance for writing script scenarios. If that is the case, consider breaking the job statements down into user stories as an intermediary step, in order to bridge the gap between high-level job statements and actionable scenarios. Learn more about the difference between job statements and user stories in How to Write JTBD.

To summarise, this is the workflow that should be followed in this step:

1. The Product Manager chooses up to 2 relevant high-priority job statements to focus on.
1. The Product Designer creates scenarios to be used for the Category Maturity Scorecard study.

If needed, PM + Product Designer can go through an intermediary step of breaking down broad job statements into feature-specific user stories and use those as guidance when creating the study scenarios.

Once the JTBDs have been decided upon, create a Category Maturity Scorecard issue.

Step 1: Define and recruit users

During the JTBD creation and validation phases, the Product Designer and Product Manager will have devised a set of user criteria to describe the user(s) you're referencing in your job(s). The same criteria should be used when recruiting for the Category Maturity Scorecard, ensuring you are gathering feedback from the right type of user(s).

To balance expediency with getting a variety of perspectives, we conduct the Category Maturity Scorecard research with five participants from one set of user criteria. If you have multiple user types for your JTBD, it is ideal to recruit 5 from each user type. To keep the study manageable, focus on no more than 2 user types per study. If more than 2 user types are required to accurately measure your JTBD, conduct a separate follow-up study for the remaining user types.

Example: A JTBD can be completed by a DevOps Engineer and a Release Manager. In this case, you'd recruit a total of 10 participants: 5 DevOps Engineers and 5 Release Managers

The recruiting criteria can be based on an existing persona, but needs to be specific enough that it can be turned into a screener survey. A screener survey should then be created in Qualtrics that your prospective participants will fill out to help you determine if they're eligible to participate.

The template survey includes a question asking people if they consent to having their session recorded. Due to the analysis required for Category Maturity Scorecards, participants must answer yes to this question in order to participate. Once your screener survey is complete, open a Recruiting request issue in the UX Research project, and assign it to the relevant Research Coordinator. The Coordinator will review your screener, reach out to you if they have any issues, and begin the recruiting process users based on the timeline you give them.

Note: Recruiting users takes time, so be sure to open the recruiting issue at least 2-3 weeks before you want to conduct your research.

Step 2: Prepare your testing environment

Testing in a production environment is the best choice because your goal is to evaluate the actual product, not a prototype that may have a slightly different experience.

Once you know what scenario(s) you'll put your participants through, it's important to determine the interface you'll use. Some questions to ask yourself:

- Can your participant use their own GitLab account? If not, can you set them up with a GitLab.com account and have them use that?
- Do you require a self-managed instance? If yes, do you need to provide one?
- Do your scenarios require any external actions? For example, do you need to display a

specific alert, or can a participant complete everything on their own?
- Does your scenario require interacting with anything besides a GitLab web-based interface? Should they receive an email or do they need to use a command-line interface?

It's important to thoroughly plan how a participant will complete your scenario(s), especially if you answered "yes" to any of the questions above. Involve technical counterparts early in the process if you have any uncertainty about how to enable users to go through your desired flow(s).

If you want help creating a pristine test environment be sure to reach out to the Demo Systems group on the demo-systems Slack channel. They can create a demo environment for users and help build any particular parameters needed for your testing environment. Be aware that setting up a test environment for a research study can be time consuming and difficult. Alternately, you can utilitze the UX Cloud Sandbox.

If your JTBD interacts with other stage groups' areas, reach out to them to ensure their part of our product will support your scenario(s).

Because this is a summative evaluation of the current experience, all of the available options the participant should need access to must be available in the GitLab instance. When you recruit participants, keep in mind the tools and features they must access to complete the JTBD scenarios.

Step 3: Document success/failure flows of your JTBD scenario(s)

Run through the scenarios yourself after they have been completed. Document what qualifies as successful completion of each scenario for future reference.

Make sure to test these scenarios with coworkers before evaluating with research participants. Ideally, the coworker(s) won't be familiar with the scenario or have an expert-level understanding. It's acceptable to coach them a little, using the pilot as a discussion to uncover any problems with your scenarios.

· Defining 'Success'

- Successful scenario completion.
- A single scenario may have several paths to the end goal that result in completion, and thereby a 'Success'. The team must identify the end goal prior to the study starting so everyone is aligned.
  - Why is this important? Identifying and being aligned on the end goal allows the moderator to accurately know what is success/failure, which is critical to know since follow-up questions are dependent on completing the scenario.
- How the participant ended up at the end goal may not be important for the team to document. If the participant took the long path and felt it was or wasn't easy, that should be reflected in their score. What matters most is if they ended up at the end goal.

· Defining 'Failure'

- Unable to complete the scenario.
- A partial completion of the scenario.

What to do if 'Failure' happens during a study

- If there is a failure, the team should try their best to understand why it occurred (ex: Was it the way the scenario was phrased? Was the experience confusing? etc.).
  - How can this be done? One way to do this is to go back at the end of the study to have the participant go through that scenario again. This time, you can ask targeted questions to understand why they took the route they took in the experience. (ex: 'It looks like you clicked on 'Issues'. Tell me more about why you selected that menu item.', 'You felt you completed the scenario at this point. What gave you the confidence that you accomplished the goal of XYZ?')
- When a participant is unable to complete a scenario, their ratings on that scenario are discarded and not accounted for when calculating the CM Scorecard score.
- If at any point you notice that less than 80% of participants are able to pass a scenario, the study should stop at that most recent participant to conserve resources.

Making note of Errors

The CM Scorecard issue template and CM Scorecard Dovetail template both contain areas to make note of errors encountered during the CM Scorecard. Errors can be considered anything significant that was off the 'happy path'. Examples may include navigating to a different area and spending time in that area trying to find what they're looking for, misinterpreting something, etc. If it's not significant and they recover quickly, then it may not be worth counting, and could simply be a mistake they made, or as a result of a testing scenario. Errors are not required for the calculation, but can be useful when justifying a failure or rating.

Step 4: Complete the test script and conduct the research

Before you can begin running your participants through your scenarios you'll need to write your test script. Because Category Maturity Scorecards are a standardized process, moderators should complete and follow this testing script as closely as possible. The moderator will typically be a Product Designer, but this is not strictly required. You are encouraged to have any relevant stakeholders attend the sessions to help take notes, but it is very important they remain silent.

Before participants go through the scenarios, make sure to emphasize that they should not think aloud. This is because the goal of CM Scorecard research is to produce data as objectively as possible. The process of thinking aloud interferes with getting objective data because it takes the user out of the experience and adds time to the study. If you wish to dig deeper on something your participant experienced, feel free to discuss that with them at the conclusion of the study. It is strongly encouraged that you conduct a usability test before a CM Scorecard study when you want to obtain mostly verbal feedback around a set of scenarios.

The 3 questions we ask

When a participant is successful at completing a scenario, they are then asked 3 questions to help us measure their experience, which we then tie back to category maturity. Note that if a participant failed at completing a scenario, there's no need to ask them these 3 questions.

At the root of how we rate/grade experiences, it arguably comes down to three main elements:

1. How easy it was to do something - this is defined as ease-of-use which has components of

usability baked within it.
1. How the user rated that experience - given our user segments, they know what a user experience is - so we can ask about it. Understanding how users felt about that experience gives them the opportunity to rate it directly, rather than having us infer their rating based on calculations.
1. Can the experience do what the user needs - this rates how well our experience matches our users' expectations based on their desired workflows and usage of similar tools.

Question 1: Single Ease Question (SEQ)

The Single Ease Question (SEQ) is a newly introduced industry-wide question based on other UX-related questions and measures. This question essentially helps us understand if the scenario was easy or difficult to complete and provides a simple and reliable way of measuring scenario-performance satisfaction. This question is also used for the UX Scorecard formative evaluation approach.

Q1: "Overall, this scenario was..."

- Extremely easy
- Easy
- Neither easy nor difficult
- Difficult
- Extremely difficult

Question 2: Satisfaction rating

Admittedly, the term 'user experience' is broad; as it encompasses many components we care about (ex: efficiency, speed, usability, etc) that are completely applicable to how one rates an overall user experience. Because of that, we're intentionally not defining 'user experience' and feel that given our audience, the definition will be collectively understood with a high level of accuracy. This question is also used for the UX Scorecard formative evaluation approach.

Q2: "How would you rate the quality of this experience?"

- Extremely good
- Good
- Neither good nor bad
- Bad
- Extremely bad

Question 3: UMUX Lite, adjusted

The UMUX Lite score is based on the UMUX (Usability Metric for User Experience), created by Finstad, and it is highly correlated with the SUS and the Net Promoter Score. It's intended to be similar to the SUS, but it's shorter and targeted toward the ISO 9241 definition of usability (effectiveness, efficiency, and satisfaction). This question is also used for the UX Scorecard formative evaluation approach.

Q3: "You just experienced our implementation of <Scenario>. How would you agree or disagree with the following statement:

<Scenario> has the features I need for what I need to do in my own work."

- Strongly agree
- Agree
- Neither agree nor disagree
- Disagree
- Strongly disagree

You will need to decide on how to compose your scenario name. Take into consideration the name we use for the category on the Category Maturity page. There may be instances where using the scenario name as we use it is not optimal for presenting to a user for getting feedback because it may not be clear enough to them.

Zoom and Respondent.io tips

When setting up a project in Respondent, make sure to use your personal Zoom room link, as you can't change the link per participant (this means each participant will have the same Zoom room link). Additionally, be sure to turn off the password requirement for these sessions.

Unmoderating testing

It's possible to conduct CM Scorecard testing unmoderated. The key is to make sure you're getting rich qualitative insights that help in understanding why participants rated the experience they way they did. Additionally, you should have the justification you need to make any iterations.

Step 5: Analyze and document your findings

Calculating the CM Scorecard score

As participants attempt to complete a scenario, for our purposes, the end result will either be: Success or Failure. To move to the next category maturity level, a minimum % pass rate is required, along with the minimum score.The chart below illustrates the relationships between: Minimum % pass rate, SUS, CM Scorecard level, and the CM Scorecard score.

Minimum % pass rate	Scale option	CM Scorecard score range	CM Scorecard level	SUS (for reference)
100%	Extremely good/easy, Strongly agree	3.95 - 5.00	Complete	78.9 - 100
> 80%	Good/Easy, agree	3.63 - 3.94	Competitive	72.6 - 78.8
> 80%	Neither	3.14 - 3.62	Viable	62.7 - 72.5
n/a	Difficult/Bad, disagree	2.59 - 3.13	--	51.7 - 62.6
n/a	Extremely bad/difficult, Strongly disagree	1.00 - 2.58	--	0 - 51.6

CM Scorecard score: The CM Scorecard score can easily be calculated for each scenario:

Tip: Use this Google Sheet(internal only), which contains the calculations already built into it.

Step one: For each scenario, enter the test participants' responses across each relevant question and document the task success/failure by using the dropdown.

Note: Do not enter in ratings for participants who experienced task failure, as those ratings are not accounted for when calculating the CM Scorecard score.

Step two: The overall score of each question and the task success rate will be averaged to provide a scenario score.

Step three: Once all of the scenario scores are calculated you will be provided an overall score and the maturity level. Check the note on the Maturity level cell (J40) for further details.

For example:

- 4.70 average = 'A' CM Scorecard grade = '78.9-100' SUS = Complete
- 3.93 average = 'B' CM Scorecard grade = '72.6 - 78.8' SUS = Competitive

Minimum % pass rate: Minimum % pass rates help indicate what percentage of participants must succeed in a scenario to meet a minimum requirement. This also helps indicate what level of scenario failure is acceptable. Scenario failures are important to note and we can't discount them, so they must be incorporated as part of the criteria to move category maturity levels. If the Minimum % pass rate for any scenario is less than 80% during a study, the study should stop at that most recent participant to conserve resources. In the event this should occur, the category maturity cannot be moved up a level. The team should take those learnings, iterate, and retest when they're ready again. It's also recommended that a retrospective take place to learn:

- What happened?
- Why weren't participants able to successfully complete the scenarios?
- What will we do to address this?

Score interpretation examples:

- A product category currently at Minimal has completed a CM Scorecard study with internal participants. The resulting score is 4.0 and the success rate is 80%. The product category can move up to Viable as it meets the minimum % pass rate. Even though the resulting 4.0 score is at Competitive level, testing the scenario with external users would be required to move the category further in maturity level. The resulting recommendation is to move the category to Viable.
- A product category currently at Viable has commpleted a CM Scorecard study with external participants. The resulting score is 3.85, but the success rate is 60%, which is below the

minimum % pass rate. In this case the product category won't move up in maturity, and it's recommended to investigate what led to the low success rate.

Post-session debriefing

It's important that the moderator and any stakeholders don't leave the call when the session concludes. Instead, remove the participant and remain on the call. Use this time for the group to debrief on what they just experienced. The notetaker(s) should take notes on this discussion.

- Have each person talk about what they feel were the major findings of the session.
- Mention any issues with the session or things that should be done differently in future studies. However, do not make changes to how planned sessions are conducted, otherwise the data can't be compared. For this reason, we suggest running a pilot session to work out any kinks.
- Allow anyone to ask any questions about the content covered or otherwise say things they feel need to be said before the session concludes.

Resulting data

By following the Category Maturity Scorecard testing script, you will have the following measures to report, per feature, not per scenario. However, scenarios may include more than one feature.

- Single Ease Question
- User Experience rating
- UMUX Lite (Adjusted) rating
- Success/failure

The goal for analyzing Category Maturity Scorecard data is to establish a baseline measure for the current experience as it relates to the JTBD(s). Over time, our product will change as new features/functions are added/changed. We can review the data collected here to understand how these changes impacted the user experience and use it to make improvements.

To analyze: Use the Google Sheet(internal only) to aid in calculating the CM Scorecard score, per scenario. Additionally, look for themes behind the reason why participants scored the way they did.

To document: Document and highlight areas for improvement via issues, utilizing the 'Actionable Insight' scoped labels, to make further improvements to the experience.

Read the UX Research team's guide for documenting insights in Dovetail.

Update JTBD data file

Several groups currently use jobstobedone.yml to showcase the current maturity of each of the jobs that represent a given categories' overarching problems they are working on solving. Each entry in the YML file consists of the following keys:

Key	Example Value	Description	Required
slug	groupjtbd1a	Unique ID of the JTBD	Yes

parent	groupjtbd1	Unique ID of the parent's JTBD	No
shortjtbd	Measuring Outcomes	A short reference of the JTBD	No (if jtbd is defined)
jtbd	When....I want to...So that	The complete JTBD	No (if shortjtbd is defined)
grade	"A"	The corresponding letter of the score of A, B, C, D, F	No
confidence	Researched	Confidence level of the grade	No
source	https://gitlab.com/gitlab-org/ux-research/-/issues/900	URL pointing to the finished research issue	No
group	Plan	The group or stage that the corresponding JTBD belongs to	No

In order to map the CM Scorecard score for a given JTBD to a grade letter, use the following criteria:

- A: 3.95 or higher
- B: Between 3.65 and 3.94
- C: Between 3.14 - 3.63
- D: Between 2 and 3.13
- F: Less than 2

SECTION: product/ux/dovetail/index.md

The UX Research team uses Dovetail to document all the research insights discovered through GitLab's UX research program. Research insights can be gathered through methods such as user interviews, usability testing, surveys, card sorts, tree tests, customer conversations, and more.

Why do we document research in Dovetail?

The UX Research team has always faced challenges in finding the best way to create research reports that are easy to digest and access. When sharing research insights via PDFs, Google docs, and even GitLab issues themselves, it was difficult to track and share study findings. Additionally, since we are often asked to readily recall information we've learned in prior studies, it can be tedious to read through old reports, look through pages of interview notes, or rewatch video recordings to find the information we need. This problem compounds, since we are continuously producing research reports and the wealth of information grows infinitely.

The goal of Dovetail is to make research findings searchable, concise, and easy to reference.

Getting started with Dovetail

1. Learn the basics of Dovetail in under 10 minutes by watching this video. For a more in depth overview of how GitLab uses and navigates through the Dovetail platform, watch this private GitLab Unfiltered video.
1. Read about Dovetail's video highlights and transcription feature.
1. Watch a walkthrough video on how to conduct qualitative data analysis within Dovetail.
1. Check out Dovetail's Help Center for commonly asked questions.
1. Check out this project (internal access only) for a great example of how to organize your data, use tags, and turn highlights into insights.

The UX Research team's guide to documenting insights in Dovetail

Creating a project

At the end of each research study, the study's DRI is responsible for documenting the research in Dovetail. The first step is to create a new project in Dovetail, under the folder that corresponds to your product stage (e.g. Manage).

1. Go to Projects.
1. Locate your stage group.
1. Click New project and select the template you need for your project. You will be redirected to the Project's ReadMe file.

Updating the ReadMe file

In the ReadMe file, update the name of your project from Problem or Solution Validation Research to something more recognizable. Ensure you add a link to your research request/brief.

As part of the template, you'll need to provide a link to your research issue in the GitLab UX Research project. Make sure to use the UX Problem Validation, UX Solution Validation, or CM Scorecard tag to ensure proper tracking of your research issue.

There is no need to add further information about your project to the ReadMe file unless you wish to do so. If you'd like to provide more context, you can describe the research methodology used in the study and any background information you may have about the research participants.

Importing raw data into Dovetail

Click Data in the left-hand menu. Add your raw data to the project, such as notes/observations taken during research sessions, video recordings, support tickets from customers, user sentiments from social media, and so on. Organize and structure your raw data in a way that resonates with you.

The following video demonstrates how to use the import feature and how to structure your data around research questions / tasks:

{{< youtube "dod5EUYYgDk" >}}

Tagging data in Dovetail

Dovetail helps you identify patterns and themes that emerge across your research data and turn those into insight statements. Once you have imported all your raw data, you are ready to start highlighting and tagging content. Think of a highlight as anything interesting that you heard or observed during a research session (for example: a user's pain point or motivation). Tag highlights with the feature/area of GitLab to which the highlight relates (for example, 'Merge Requests') and the persona (for example, 'Sasha: Software Developer') who made the comment, if possible.

A bit like affinity mapping, tags in Dovetail help you identify and keep track of patterns that emerge across your research data. A single highlight can have one or many tags associated with it. More help can be found on our Analyzing and synthesizing user data handbook page.

Enable Global Tags in your Project

As a way to keep GitLab's research more consistent, we encourage everyone to utilize GitLab's global tags available in Dovetail, which are maintained by the UX Research Team. When research is performed in a consistent manner, it makes gathering insights across stages or over long periods of time much easier. To help move towards that goal of consistent research, try to incorporate global tags and follow our tagging best practices when synthesizing qualitative research. A good goal to have is 50% of tags in your project coming from the global tags.

There are two sets of tags available for your projects. You may use either set whenever you want, as well as your own custom tags, but be aware you will have to enable the tags for each project. When summarizing your research, first look at the global tags, and then the section tags when appropriate, and lastly create your own tags. The differences between the two sets of tags is shown below:

- GitLab Global Tags which contain tags that can be used across all stage groups for a wide range of projects, but particularly useful for solution validation. Try to look at these tags first.
- GitLab Section Tags which contain tags organized by section, which can be used for more feature specific, feature-related work.

This video contains a walkthrough of the steps below to enable a global tag on your project:

1. Open the project you are working on
1. Click on the plus icon next to Tags
1. Choose Use an existing board
1. Under the Workspace tab, select GitLab Global Tags and Link to project
1. You will now see GitLab Global Tags appear as a board under Tags
1. Repeat steps 3-5 to enable GitLab Section Tags
1. Repeat this process for each project you are working on

How to use Global Tags with your notes

Just like manually created tags, global tags can be used by highlighting the text you want to tag, and clicking on the global tag you have enabled. This is shown in the image below:

Tags are organized into categories, so you may want to familiarize yourself with the organization of tags and their categories.

When to use Global Tags

Global tags can be used as a way to supplement manual tagging by providing standardization and structure. They are not meant to be the only source of tags used in your project. Due to the uniqueness of each research project, there may often be times when creating a new tag is more helpful than using one of the global tags.

Example: When conducting a user interview, try to identify the users' feelings towards a particular experience. There may be a number of times when you will want to use tags from the GitLab Global Tags such as feature request & frustrated when talking about an experience. Those insights may not be specific enough for your research, so creating additional tags like wants a drop-down for options can also be used.

A good goal to set for your project is to have 50% of your tags come from global tags.

If you are unsure about whether to create your own tag or use an existing global tag, first think about what would generate the most informative insights. If a global tag can be used while preserving the accuracy of the insights, then stick to that. Otherwise, follow our best practices for creating tags in dovetail.

What tags are available?

GitLab team members may view the Global Dovetail Tags Google Sheet that is maintained by the UX Research team.

GitLab Global Tags are organized into six categories:

Category	Details	Example
User Action	These tags can be used to indicate what a user did while using the UI.	A user might be unsure what to do when given a task, and then proceeds to go down the wrong path.
User Feedback	Useful to describe what a user said during their research session. Also a set of tags with generic options (A through D) which can be used in Solution Validation. 	A user might have a feature request when talking about a functionality they want in their workflow. Or, the user could Prefer Option B in a design evaluation.
User Emotion	These tags are related to the user's attitude towards the UI, like in a usability test or walkthrough.	A user could feel overwhelmed when being presented with a UI.
Workflow	Can be used to track the user's actions in their workflow specifically. Also a subset of tags with generic task numbers (1-10), which can be used for usability tests or UX Scorecards.	You could use the unsuccessful end task tag if a user finished a series of tasks, but missed a key deliverable. Or, you may want to keep track of when a user finished task 1 and task 2.
Personas	Each tag relates to one of our user personas, or characteristics of those personas. Use these tags when looking for jobs or features that correspond to certain personas.	When a user configures a static scanner, they could be Amy, Application Security Engineer. Or, if you are performing foundational research on the users' organization, you could use enterprise or start-up tags.
JTBD	Most of the tags relate to the various stages in mapping jobs. Can be used when performing foundational jobs research such as contextual inquiries.	When conducting a contextual, a user may talk about monitoring their pipeline, which could be tagged with Step in Job - monitor.

Global tag definitions

User Action Tags

Tag	Definition
Workaround	Participant completes task in a way other than the predicted "Happy Path".
Seeks help	Participant needs assistance from the moderator or other sources during the session.
Unsure what to do	Participant gets stuck and is not confident on how to proceed.
Focuses on UI element	Participant is spending time on a particular interface element.
Confused by UI element	Participant is confused by a particular interface element.
Undo previous action	Participant reverses the progress they made in the task.
Understands goal	Participant gives the desired feedback on the main task.
Blocker	Participant is blocked from completing their task.
Configuration	Participant makes changes to settings or their profile.

User Feedback Tags

Tag	Definition
Prefer option A	Participant picks option A.
Prefer option B	Participant picks option B.
Prefer option C	Participant picks option C.
Prefer option D	Participant picks option D.
General insights	Feedback that is outside of the scope of a particular product team or feature set.
Feedback on UI	Feedback that is focused on design elements.
Feedback on UX	Feedback that is focused on the user experience.
Opportunity	Feedback that is focused on the user experience.
Pain point	A specific or general instance where the product gets in the way of the participant's task.
Feature request	Participant makes requests for a specific and particular feature to be added to the product.
Feature requirement	Participant identifies the aspect(s) of a feature that the product should have for the current project.
Missing functionality or feature	Participant expresses that the product is missing some functionality or feature.
Answer to question	Participant answers a question that was posed by the moderator.
Rationale for decision	Participant clarifies or expands upon their thinking on a particular topic.

User Emotion Tags

Tag	Definition
Positive	Participant expresses positive statements towards the product.
Mixed feelings	Participant expresses conflicting feelings or emotions towards the product.
Negative	Participant expresses negative statements towards the product.
Delighted	Participant feels or shows great pleasure towards the product.
Excited	Participant is very enthusiastic and eager towards the product.

Interested	Participant shows curiosity or concern about something towards the product.
Satisfied	Participant is content or pleased towards the product.
Indifferent	Participant feels unconcerned or has no particular interest towards the product.
Confused	Participant is unable to think clearly about the product.
Frustrated	Participant expresses distress or annoyance towards the product.
Disappointed	Participant is sad or displeased in the product.
Dissatisfied	Participant feels a large amount of displeasure towards the product.
Overwhelmed	Participant feels inundated or that something is too much to handle in the product.

Workflow Tags

Tag	Definition
Workflow	Participant goes through a particular end to end experience in the product.
Task 1	Participant performs the first task.
Task 2	Participant performs the second task.
Task 3	Participant performs the third task.
Task 4	Participant performs the fourth task.
Task 5	Participant performs the fifth task.
Task 6	Participant performs the sixth task.
Task 7	Participant performs the seventh task.
Task 8	Participant performs the eighth task.
Task 9	Participant performs the ninth task.
Task 10	Participant performs the tenth task.
Start task	Participant starts the task.
Successful end task	Participant completes the task successfully.
Unsuccessful end task	Participant gets to the end of the tasks, but did not fulfill a primary requirement.
Failed task	Participant unable to finish a task.
Doesn't understand task	Participant is confused and misinterprets the task instructions.
Mistake in workflows	Participant makes a mistake in the workflow which is easily correctable.
Critical mistake in workflow	Participant makes a mistake in the workflow which cannot be reversed or corrected.
Group-level interaction	Participant approaches UX with a group-centric orientation.
Project-level interaction	Participant approaches UX with a project-centric orientation.
Group/project	Participant has feedback about either a group or a project.

Personas Tags

Tag	Definition
Parker, Product Manager	Participant's role or tasks match with Parker.
Delaney, Development Team Lead	Participant's role or tasks match with Delaney.
Presley, Product Designer	Participant's role or tasks match with Presley.
Sasha, Software Developer	Participant's role or tasks match with Sasha.
Devon, DevOps Engineer	Participant's role or tasks match with Devon.
Sidney, Systems Administrator	Participant's role or tasks match with Sidney.

Rachel, Release Manager	Participant's role or tasks match with Rachel.
Simone, Software Engineer in Test	Participant's role or tasks match with Simone.
Allison, Application Ops	Participant's role or tasks match with Allison.
Ingrid, Infrastructure Operator	Participant's role or tasks match with Ingrid.
Dakota, Application Development Director	Participant's role or tasks match with Dakota.
Amy, Application Security Engineer	Participant's role or tasks match with Amy.
Isaac, Infrastructure Security Engineer	Participant's role or tasks match with Isaac.
Alex, Security Operations Engineer	Participant's role or tasks match with Alex.
Cameron, Compliance Manager	Participant's role or tasks match with Cameron.
New or unknown persona	User persona that we haven't previously identified in our handbook.
Buyer personas	Users who serve as the main buyer in an organization or a champion within an enterprise that drives the buying conversation.
Team leader	User who is in a management role and does have direct reports.
C-Suite Executive	User who is a high-ranking executive in an organization (CEO, CIO, CFO, etc.).
Individual Contributor	User who is not in a management role and does not have direct reports.
Enterprise	Companies with 1,000 or more employees.
SMB- Small Medium Business	Companies with up to 1,000 employees.
Start-up	Young company founded to develop a unique product or service.
SaaS	Current GitLab SaaS user. They log into GitLab.com to access their account.
Self-managed	Current GitLab self-managed user. They maintain their own GitLab instance.

Jobs and Tools Tags

Tag	Definition
Step in job (define)	Participant understands how a process works.
Step in job (locate)	Participant understands and navigates to where they need to go.
Step in job (prepare)	Participant prepares for a major step in a job.
Step in job (confirm)	Participant reviews or validates a step in the job.
Step in job (execute)	Participant executes a step in the job.
Step in job (monitor)	Participant monitors the outcomes of the step in the job.
Step in job (modify)	Participant modifies the previous step in the job.
Step in job (conclude)	Participant finishes the steps in the job.
Job goal	A clear demonstration of what the purpose of the job is for.
Possible JTBD insight	Participant mentions a general insight related to a JTBD.
Tool in job	Participant points out tools that are used when performing a job.
Critical tool in job	Participant points out tools that are crucial for performing a job.

Can we add more tags?

The global tags are an iterative process which will continue to grow in the future. We strongly encourage feedback from stakeholders so we can tailor the list to suit as many needs as possible.

If you believe the tag library is incomplete or in need of editing, please send a message to the uxresearch Slack channel. We expect to add tags incrementally over time as more feedback and research is done, and therefore may not add a particular tag immediately, so creating a custom tag can be a helpful short-term solution.

Dovetail Tagging Best Practices

Many projects will need a mix of custom tags in addition to some global tags. In Dovetail, you can create any tag you want to help distill your user data into pieces of evidence for insights. While this is useful, this can also be problematic. Here's why:

- These tags do not carry over from one project to another, making it difficult to identify similar insights across projects.
- The tags can be named anything. This results in a large number of similarly-themed tags, which makes it difficult to search by insights across projects (for example: tags such as opportunity, opportunities, opportunity for UI).

To properly manage research insights within Dovetail, here are some do's and don'ts when creating your own tags.

Do's

- Tag the data while it's fresh in your mind
  - Tag your data immediately after conducting the sessions, or after re-reading your transcripts. Having everything fresh in your mind will make themes more clear.
- Align your tags with your research hypothesis
  - The goal of each tag is to link your user data to your research goals. Each tag should be directly related to one of your research hypotheses.
- Be consistent
  - When you identify what tags you will be using, stick to them. The more consistent our tags are, the easier it is to find trends in our data.
- Less is more
  - It is better to have 5 tags that you are confident in than 10 tags you aren't. As a guideline, try to limit most studies to less than 15 tags.
- Think about how they'll be used
  - Assume that someday, someone other than yourself will use your tags to identify similar insights. Make it easy for them to do that.
- Take a second look
  - After making your tags, take a small break and then read over them one more time.

Don'ts

- Do not use full sentences
  - A tag should be 1-3 words long. Using multiple different tags will result in more useful insights than one longer tag.
- Do not use emoji
  - Emoji are naturally more ambiguous than text, and tags should be as clear as possible.

Poor Tag Examples	Better Tag Examples
User is confused by navigation and fails the task	Confusion, Navigation failure, Task failure
· Features communicate the problem being solved and value to a new user	Positive Value

| Lack of clarity for some users | Confusion |

Creating cross-stage awareness using shared tags

While importing the raw data from user research, sometimes there are insights which are useful to other stages and/or groups than your own. The extensions feature within Dovetail allows for creating tags which can be used across projects. You can use these extension tags to make cross-stage content more discoverable by other stages and/or groups.

Best practices to follow while using the global tags under Shared Tags extension:

- First, you must add the extentions to your project. You will need to repeat this process for each new project you start. To do this, navigate to the Settings page for your respective project, and under the Extensions tab, link the already created Shared Tags extension to your project.
- Next, navigate to the Tags page of your project. You will now see that extension tags are now available to use in your project. Now that the extensions are available to your project, you just need add them to your insights. Locate insights that could be valuable to other sections, stages or groups and add the appropriate extension tags.
- Be sure to double check the list of Extension tags before you add a new tag. Since this list is available to everyone in the GitLab Dovetail account, you might find that your tag already exists.
- Only use a single global tag for the highlighted content. For example, use the name of the related stage group to create the tag for that insight. Otherwise, apply a tag using the related stage name. And if you're unsure of what stage to use, mention the product section instead.
- All the content highlighted with these global tags across projects can be tracked by selecting GitLab Global Tags within the extension page found within settings.

Charts & Insights

The next step is to create insight statements for your study and support them with the evidence you gathered in the tags, highlights, and charts. Use Charts to quickly get an overview of how frequently themes are mentioned across your research data. Themes that frequently reoccur in your data warrant an insight. Insights help you to summarise your research findings. Select multiple highlights in order to create an insight.

Sometimes during research studies you'll note something of interest but perhaps don't have enough data yet to decide whether what you observed or heard was an edge case or something which may be impacting other users.

A general rule of thumb: If you're uncertain about whether something should be turned into an insight and/or only have 1-2 highlights that support the theme. Your observation should remain as a highlight rather than be converted into an insight.

Highlights can still be searched, tracked and revisited again in the future when you've gathered more research data.

Sharing your findings

After you've created your insight statements, you can use Dovetail's "presentation mode" feature to share your findings with your team and any other stakeholders. The last step is to provide a link to the Dovetail project directly in the original UX Research issue. Check out this project (internal link only) as a great example of these steps.

Suggestions for managing your content

This video demonstrates how to take structured notes in Dovetail similarly to a Google Sheet with multiple notetakers.

{{< youtube "K7WuC0QCOyM" >}}

Disable Public Access

In order to protect PII (Personally Identifiable Information), ensure that your project settings for insights are disabled for public access. To do this you navigate to your project and click Insights. From there, ensure your share settings look like this:

Frequently Asked Questions

I'm a Product Manager. Can I use Dovetail to keep track of the calls I have with customers?

Yes! When creating a new project, please select the Customer calls template. In the ReadMe file, update the name of your project from Customer calls to something more recognisable. Continue to follow the steps outlined under the UX Research team's guide to documenting insights in Dovetail starting with Importing raw data into Dovetail.

Note: If you're only speaking to one customer and haven't heard evidence from other customers that they are experiencing the same problem or want the same feature improvement, it's highly likely that your finding should remain as a highlight rather than be converted into an insight. Feel free to reach out to your UX Researcher if you're not sure.

My team counterparts need access to the research insights in Dovetail. Can I add them to Dovetail?

Yes, you can add your team counterparts to Dovetail with view-only access. It will allow them to view the insights and the related data without affecting our number of available licenses.

To add a your counterparts to Dovetail, follow the steps below:

1. Click on your profile image at the top right of the app
1. Select profile in the menu
1. Go to settings at the top left near the search bar (note: not the settings option in the left nav)
1. Select users in the left nav
1. Click on invite users button
1. Type in email addresses of people on your team and select viewer access for Markup, Playback, and Backstage

1. Click to send the invite

I'd like an idea of how to structure my data in Dovetail, do you have any examples?

Yes, scroll to the bottom of the Project list and under Sample data, you will see some sample projects created by the folks at Dovetail.

I'd like to create a private project to synthesize sensitive information

While our Dovetail projects are currently only accessible by GitLab employees, sometimes you have a project you feel should be only seen by you or a few others. You do this by controlling who has access to your project.

Guidelines for what constitutes sensitive information

When documenting research insights in Dovetail or research issues, it is extremely important not to disclose any personally identifiable information (PII) of participants. This is to ensure their feedback and identity is kept confidential and is only available to those who need to know. For example, when giving a title to a session recording, noting down session summaries or using a quote, instead of referring to a participant by their full name use "participant [number]" or the corresponding user persona.

For more information, please refer to our Code of Business Conduct & Ethics.

Feedback and questions

Please post feedback and questions in the uxresearch Slack channel.

If you find out something useful which you feel will benefit others, please submit an MR to this page and assign it to @asmolinski2.

SECTION: product/ux/how-we-work/_index.md

SECTION: product/ux/how-we-work/design-pair-rotation.md

Design Pairs

Pair designing gives Product Designers a consistent partner to ideate with at the beginning of an effort, get feedback from during the design process, and conduct design reviews. It also gives Product Designers exposure to product areas outside of their own.

- New designer pairs are connected every six months.
- Pairing assignments should be composed of designers from different stages (e.g., a Plan designer should pair with someone outside of the Plan stage).

- If we have an odd number of designers, we'll have one 3-person partnership.
- Pairs decide what to share and when; there is no predefined schedule or guidelines.
- It's imperative to ask for feedback and give context.

Collaboration suggestions

Collaborating on key activities offers a unique opportunity to broaden your knowledge across different areas of GitLab. This cross-functional collaboration not only enriches your skill set but can also cultivate a deeper understanding of the product as a whole. Try some of these suggestions when working with your design pair:

- Perform design reviews on each other's designs.
- Walk your design pair through your product areas primary use cases to familiarize them with it.
- Use part of your pairing sessions to ensure local environments are set up and ready for reviews in your respective product areas. Collaborate on MR reviews to learn more about the product area and provide UX feedback to your design pair.
- Perform Buddy UX Scorecard: Heuristic Evaluations (Buddy Template) on each other's primary use cases.
- Collaborate on solution validation for each other's product areas (write scripts, take notes, observe, assess interview data).
- Talk about your current challenges as a designer. You don't always need to share visuals. Your design pair may have experience with a similar challenge and can share ways they worked through it.

Schedule

This is the rotation schedule for FY26